

The Appearance of Knowledge: What Socrates Shows Us About AI

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Today, we are surrounded by predictions that artificial intelligence will either make human intelligence "superhuman" or make it obsolete. It can feel as if we are the first generation to face a tool powerful enough to change how people think, learn, and communicate. But the fear that a technology might reshape the mind is not new. In the fifth century BCE, Socrates raised a similar worry about writing. In Plato's *Phaedrus*, he warns that writing can make people appear knowledgeable without forcing them to practice memory, questioning, or live dialogue. That warning matters for AI today: when we use AI to avoid the difficult work of thinking, it creates the appearance of understanding, but when we use it to ask better questions, test ideas, and keep learning active, it can become a tool for deeper understanding.

Socrates' concern is not simply that writing exists. His deeper concern is that writing can separate words from the living process that gives them meaning. He argues that writing "will introduce forgetfulness into the soul of those who learn it" because people will rely on external marks rather than drawing knowledge from within themselves (Plato 551). In other words, a written answer can look complete even when the person reading or repeating it has not truly understood it. The danger is not the page itself. The danger is mistaking access to information for knowledge.

AI creates a similar temptation. A chatbot can produce an answer that sounds organized, confident, and persuasive within seconds. That speed is useful, but it can also hide the struggle that normally turns information into understanding. For example, a student who asks AI to summarize a reading may receive a clean explanation, but if the student never wrestles with the

passage, asks why the author makes certain claims, or tries to put the idea into their own words, the explanation remains outside of them. It is remembered by the tool, not by the learner. This is why Socrates' critique still applies: knowledge is not only the final sentence we can repeat, but the process by which we arrive there.

This problem becomes clearer when we think about attention. David Abram describes the "animate world" as the living, sensory world around us, a world that asks us to notice, respond, and participate (Abram 113). Mindless scrolling pulls attention in the opposite direction. Imagine opening TikTok to answer one notification and then spending half an hour moving through videos about dorm rooms, food, fashion, and jokes that disappear as soon as the next one begins. Nothing terrible has happened, but the mind has been trained to receive without responding. A friend could be sitting nearby, trying to tell a story, while the screen keeps offering easier stimulation. In that moment, the problem is not that the phone contains language or images. The problem is that the user is present physically while mentally outsourcing attention to the feed. L. M. Sacasas makes a similar point about language and AI. He argues that "the outsourcing of the labor of articulation is the outsourcing of a fundamentally human activity" (Sacasas). Articulation is not just a way to display finished thoughts; it is how thoughts become clear in the first place. The struggle to find the right words forces us to discover what we actually mean. When AI does that work for us too quickly, we may end up with language that sounds intelligent but does not fully belong to us.

The dating profile is a small but useful example. Imagine someone asks AI to write a profile that makes them sound funny, emotionally mature, adventurous, and thoughtful. The profile may attract attention because the language is polished. But when another person asks a follow-up question, the polished version begins to crack. The problem is not that AI helped with

grammar. The problem is that the profile replaced self-knowledge with performance. Socrates warns that written words can make people "appear to be wise instead of really being so" (Plato 552). AI can produce the same illusion when it gives us a finished voice before we have done the unfinished work of knowing what we want to say.

Still, Socrates' critique does not mean that we should reject AI entirely. Even in *Phaedrus*, writing is not useless. Written words can serve as reminders for people who already know and want to return to an idea (Plato 552). AI can work in a similar way when it supports thinking instead of replacing it. The difference depends on how the tool is used. Asking AI to complete a paper, write a personal message, or provide an answer without effort weakens understanding. Asking AI to challenge a thesis, generate counterarguments, or ask follow-up questions can make the thinking process more active.

This is where AI tutoring becomes important. Khan Academy's Khanmigo is one example of an AI tool designed to guide rather than simply answer. Sal Khan describes Khanmigo as a tutor that asks questions and supports "productive struggle" rather than handing students the final response (Khan). That model is closer to the Socratic method because it keeps the learner involved. Instead of replacing the student's thinking, the tutor can ask what the student already knows, where the confusion begins, and what step might come next.

At the same time, the limits matter. Khan also admits that AI can make mistakes and that there is "a long way to go" before these tools can be trusted without caution (Khan). This point is important because an AI tutor is not the same as a skilled human teacher. A human teacher can notice hesitation, emotion, boredom, and confusion in ways that a chatbot may miss. AI can imitate the structure of dialogue, but it cannot fully replace the relationship that makes dialogue

meaningful. That is why AI should not be treated as an authority. It should be treated as a practice partner.

Socrates' warning helps us draw a practical line. If AI gives us words that allow us to skip memory, attention, or articulation, then it weakens understanding. If AI helps us return to an idea, question our assumptions, and explain a thought more clearly in our own words, then it can strengthen understanding. The tool itself is not the final problem. The danger is overreliance. The irony is that Socrates' warning against writing survived because Plato wrote it down. That does not make Socrates wrong. It shows that tools can preserve thought when they are used carefully. Writing can either flatten dialogue into fixed words or carry a living argument into the future. AI has the same double possibility. It can make people sound wise without becoming wise, or it can push them to think harder than they would have on their own.

The real test is not whether we use AI, but how we use it. We should write before asking it to rewrite, think before asking it to summarize, and question its answers instead of accepting them because they sound fluent. AI should be used less like a shortcut and more like a conversation partner: something that asks us to explain, revise, and defend our own thinking. If we use it that way, AI does not have to replace understanding. It can remind us that understanding was never just about having the right answer; it was about doing the work required to make that answer our own.

Works Cited

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